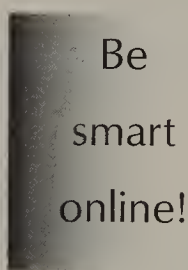


Don't take it lightly. Identity theft is a real threat. I hear stories every day from people like Kurt and Meredith. It is more common with every year that goes by. Sometimes people are too careless with their private financial information, but usually identity theft happens because the bad guys are very good at what they do.

The easiest way to be alert to possible identity theft is to monitor your credit report. If Kurt had been using a monitoring service or if he had pulled his own free credit report, he would have noticed this whopper of a debt on his own.

Stay on top of your affairs and you can head off problems a lot quicker.

Basic Security



Besides the obvious tips, like not to give out your credit card number or social security number over the phone, you should invest in an inexpensive home shredder. Any receipt or statement with your personal information should be shredded. I have a friend who throws her receipts in the garbage and then pours spaghetti sauce over them. A shredder is probably a little neater.

A lot of the identity theft occurs online, so be smart when you are on your computer. Some basic safety tips to remember include:

- ✓ Always log off when you have finished your online banking or credit card transaction.
- ✓ Only use your own computer to do your personal financial business. Do not use the computer at the public library; do not use your laptop on the free wireless network at the coffee shop or the bookstore.
- ✓ Don't click on pop-ups.
- ✓ Don't download anything unless you are certain that it is safe.
- ✓ Make up an extremely creative password.
- ✓ Run antivirus and/or security software.